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An Indian Debate on Optical Reflections and Its Metaphysical Implications

Śaiva Nondualism and the Mirror of Consciousness*

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Mirrors and other reflecting entities are banal yet puzzling objects: endowed with the extraordinary ability to make us perceive what we would otherwise remain unable to see (such as our own face), they also offer a somewhat disturbing vision of the world, showing things where they are not (our face *in* the mirror) or providing them with properties that they cannot possess—by virtue of their strange power, tiny elephants appear in glittering jewels and multiple suns shine on a rough water. As Karin Preisendanz once noted, if Indian optics "did not emerge as a distinct science or pre-science in India …, optical theories were developed, problems realized, and solutions attempted," but always within the larger frame of philosophical speculations,[1] and optical reflections (*pratibimba* in Sanskrit) are no exception: in classical India, the question of how they occur was primarily discussed in connection with that of their problematic ontological status. Are reflections as unsubstantial as mirages, or do they hold some reality, and if so, in what way do they exist? Moreover, this ontological discussion itself was often embedded in a more encompassing metaphysical debate, one that had as its stake the very reality of the phenomenal world. For if consciousness can be compared (as many Indian thinkers believed) to a mirror reflecting the objects of which it is aware, then we are also entitled to ask in what way the reflections within that mirror can be said to exist.

The following pages are an attempt to understand how real the perceived world is according to the Śaiva nondualist philosophers Utpaladeva (c. 925–975 CE) and Abhinavagupta (c. 975–1025 CE) on the basis of their position in a debate on the nature of optical reflections. This debate might at first sight appear as a minor digression in Utpaladeva's magnum opus—the Pratyabhijñā (Recognition) treatise[2]—and Abhinavagupta's two commentaries thereon.[3] It is, however, crucial for the understanding of the Śaiva nondualists' ontology, and later Indian authors often present it as a defining feature of Utpaladeva's system.[4] According to the Śaiva nondualistic scriptures,

the universe only exists within Śiva understood as a single, all-encompassing, and all-powerful consciousness manifesting itself in an infinite variety of forms; and the Śaiva philosophers express this absolute idealism by saying that the perceived universe is nothing but reflections on the mirror of consciousness.[5]

Modern scholarship has already pointed out this recurring use of the mirror analogy in Śaiva nondualistic literature and offered interpretations of it.[6] The goal of this chapter is to highlight its philosophical import while emphasizing two often overlooked points: first, contrary to what is usually assumed in secondary literature, this analogy is probably no novelty on Abhinavagupta's part[7] and was in all likelihood already fully present in Utpaladeva's works.[8] Second, in order to understand the meaning of the Śaiva contention that phenomena are like reflections, we must strive to understand what reflections are *not* according to the Śaivas. For the Pratyabhijñā treatise and its commentaries endeavor to provide the dogmas contained in the Śaiva nondualistic scriptures with a rational justification, and they do so by systematically engaging in a philosophical dialogue with rival schools of thought. Utpaladeva's work is profoundly polemical[9] and we can hope to gain a fuller understanding of the Śaiva comparison of phenomena with reflections if we are able to determine in what way this comparison is a response to other, non-Śaiva theories regarding the nature of reflections and the reason(s) why phenomena might be compared to reflections.

Reflections are nothing but the reflecting entity: Vasubandhu's thesis

Giving an overview of all the positions held in the Indian debate over the nature of reflections is far beyond the scope of this chapter; but we can start our enquiry by outlining a few theses that were in all probability known of the Śaivas. Among Buddhist philosophers,[10] Vasubandhu (fourth to fifth centuries CE?), the author of the AKBh (a work that Abhinavagupta undoubtedly knew),[11] played a particularly important role in this debate.

Determining whether reflections have some kind of reality was already an important issue in Vasubandhu's time, particularly in intra-Buddhistic debates involving Sarvāstivādins (who contended that all things exist in some form at all times and therefore defended the reality of reflections) and Dārṣṭāntikas (who claimed that reflected images do not actually exist because the reflected object cannot enter the reflecting surface although it seems to do so).[12] Thus in the AKBh,[13] Vasubandhu sets out to show that reflections have no reality whatsoever and gives several reasons why they must be mere illusions: two distinct entities (the mirror and its reflection) cannot coexist in the same place[14]; two observers watching the same mirror from different points of view do not see the same reflections in it[15]; whereas light and darkness are incompatible, the sun can be reflected in a mirror placed in the shade[16]; and although the mirror has no depth, we do not see the reflected moon on the surface of the mirror, but rather, somewhere beyond it.[17] Vasubandhu concludes that reflections are "nothing at all that would exist," that is, nothing that would be distinct from the mirror[18]: when we see reflections

in fact we see nothing but the reflecting entity, but we are deluded into seeing something besides the mirror because of a particular causal complex involving the presence of a mirror, light, a specific angle, and so on.[19]

Reflections are nothing but the reflected object: the position held by Naiyāyikas and Mīmāṃsakas

On the Brahmanical side, the reality of reflections is also denied. Thus the Naiyāyikas agree with Vasubandhu that we are mistaken in thinking that we actually perceive such things as reflections.[20] But according to Brahmanical authors, reflections are illusions not because they would be nothing apart from the reflecting entity itself, but rather, because upon seeing a reflection in a mirror, we see nothing but the reflected object (*bimba*) itself. In order to understand this thesis we should keep in mind that according to the Naiyāyikas vision occurs thanks to some invisible rays emanating from the eyes and coming into direct contact with the object to be perceived.[21] Pakṣilasvāmin (fifth century CE?) therefore explains that when we see our face in a mirror, the visual rays bounce back upon reaching the surface of the mirror and end up directly touching the face.[22] As Uddyotakara (sixth century CE?) specifies, in such a case we mistakenly believe that we perceive an object consisting in an image of our face and residing in the mirror because our perception of the mirror and the immediately posterior perception of our face occur too quickly for us to realize that these are two different objects in two different places.[23]

The Mīmāṃsakas seem to have adopted the Naiyāyikas' general theory regarding optics[24] and their understanding of the phenomenon of optical reflection is quite similar.[25] Thus the Mīmāṃsaka Kumārila (sixth century CE?) also claims that when perceiving what we believe to be a reflection of the sun, in fact we grasp nothing but the sun itself, but we are deluded into thinking that we see a reflected image that has an existence of its own because the visual rays are diverted upon reaching the surface of the reflecting entity: when we contemplate a reflection of the sun in water, in fact our visual rays are in contact with the sun itself.[26] Similarly, Pārthasārathimiśra (who lived at some point between the tenth and thirteenth centuries CE) insists that reflections do not exist as such. Quite amusingly, in order to demonstrate this he invokes arguments very close to those used by the Buddhist Vasubandhu[27] before offering a conclusion that has a much more orthodox ring from a Brahmanical point of view: reflections are nothing because when we perceive them we only grasp the reflected object.[28]

A Buddhist critique of the Brahmanical position: Śāntarakṣita's claim that reflections have no objective support

Vasubandhu's position was defended and refined in the eighth century by Śāntarakṣita and his disciple Kamalaśīla, who both emphasize their debt toward the author of the AKBh by ostentatiously paraphrasing his arguments against the reality of reflections.[29] Śāntarakṣita (whose TS might well have influenced Utpaladeva)[30] thus explains that

reflections are a mere illusion (*bhrānti*)—that is, in fact they are nothing at all[31]—on the grounds that (1) two distinct material objects cannot exist in the same place[32]; (2) two observers differently located do not see the same reflection in the same place[33]; and (3) although the mirror has no depth, we see reflected objects as if they were below the mirror's surface.[34] Śāntarakṣita and Kamalaśīla also criticize the view that the image seen in the mirror has a reality of its own by showing that whether we consider the mirror as a lasting entity or whether we accept the Buddhist view of universal momentariness, the mirror can never start bearing a reflection. For if the mirror has a lasting existence it cannot be endowed with changing reflections (which would alter its nature and make it impermanent); it must therefore reflect the same image (or no image at all) forever.[35] But if we concede its momentariness, we must also admit that at every moment there arises a different mirror bearing a different reflection, so that the mirror, lasting or not, can never *acquire* a reflection—an absurdity which vanishes if we accept that the reflection is a mere illusion.[36] Finally, contrary to what the Brahmanical authors (i.e., here, mainly Kumārila's followers)[37] claim, the perception of the reflection cannot have an external, objective support (*ālambana*) in the form of the reflected object itself, because the reflection and the reflected object have strikingly different appearances[38]: the reflection of my face in a mirror is located in front of my own body instead of being part of it, it faces the opposite direction and has a different size, color, and so on according to the particular properties of the object that reflects it.[39] And Kumārila cannot rightfully claim that these two very different appearances share a single objective support, because this contradicts another thesis of his according to which the aspect or appearance (*ākāra*) of objects does not belong to consciousness. For the Mīmāṃsaka denies that a cognition grasps the object that it perceives by taking on its form: according to him the appearance of the perceived object is, rather, a property inherent in the object itself.[40] But by defending such a thesis he loses the ability to explain the occurrence of erroneous perceptions in which we mistakenly apprehend an object as located in a place where in fact it is not found, whereas he himself describes the perception of reflections as a mistaken apprehension of this type.[41]

The metaphysical stake in this optical debate: phenomena as reflections within consciousness

As noted above, in classical India optical theories were formulated in connection with philosophical debates, and the discussion on the nature of reflections is no exception. One of its main philosophical contexts[42] is the issue of the ontological status of the phenomenal world. Thus the contention that the reality of the perceived universe is comparable to that of a reflection is a topos of Buddhist texts[43] both in Madhyamaka literature (where it usually conveys the idea that all things are "devoid of intrinsic nature," *niḥsvabhāva*)[44] and in the Vijñānavāda. In this latter tradition, which propounds the thesis that everything is consciousness,[45] it is often found along with the more famous dream analogy (according to which perceived objects have no more reality than dreamt objects)[46] and it is used to show that all ordinary perceptions are devoid of any external support.[47] Vasubandhu and his Buddhist contemporaries were certainly already

aware of the implications of the discussion over the reality of reflected images for the ontological status of the perceived universe[48]; and in later Indian philosophical texts these implications become more and more transparent as the Vijñānavādins elaborate their critique of a rival Buddhist thesis (usually ascribed to the Sautrāntikas) according to which the reason why we perceive various objects is the existence of an external world casting a reflection of itself onto consciousness.[49] By way of contrast, according to the Vijñānavādins reflections are mere illusions (when perceiving them we wrongly believe that we are grasping an object called "reflection" independent of our perception of the mirror), just as, when perceiving any object of the world, we mistakenly assume that this object has an existence of its own, independently of the cognition manifesting it. While defending the Vijñānavāda, Buddhist authors such as Śāntarakṣita and Kamalaśīla[50] therefore explain that precisely because cognitions of reflections appear to present an external object while reflections are in fact nonexistent, we must consider that similarly, all perceived objects have no reality outside of consciousness.[51]

As for the theory of reflections held by the Naiyāyikas and Mīmāṃsakas, whether or not it was primarily designed as an answer to the Buddhist idealists, it is from this perspective that Śāntarakṣita and Kamalaśīla understand it. Thus according to them Kumārila is mainly concerned with showing that all cognitions must have a substrate external to consciousness: our dreams only appear not to correspond to any reality, since dream objects really are combinations of previously perceived entities; and similarly, reflections only seem to be unsubstantial, but in fact the perception of the sun's reflection in the water, far from apprehending a nonexistent entity, grasps a real, existing sun in the sky. And as a consequence the Vijñānavādin cannot rely on such cognitions to argue that all perceived objects are devoid of any external basis.[52]

Finally, it should be noted that Kumārila's explanation of optical reflections was adopted by some of the proponents of Advaita Vedānta.[53] However, while in the Mīmāṃsā the theory of optical reflection served to emphasize that even illusions such as reflections have an external support (so that one cannot deny the reality of the external world on the grounds that such illusions occur), the Vedāntins rather exploited the analogy of phenomena with reflections to establish their nondualism[54]: they used it to show that the variety of the phenomenal world is an illusion[55] since it is only the result of our distorted apprehension of reality,[56] and since in fact this unreal appearance of diversity occurs on the basis of the absolute unity of the Brahman.[57]

What reflections (and phenomena) are *not* according to the Śaivas: neither illusions, nor the reflected object itself

As for the Śaiva nondualists, paradoxically for authors who came to be known as the proponents of a "doctrine [that phenomena are similar to] reflections" (*pratibimbavāda*), they often seem to mistrust this analogy of reflections. The reason for this is that they defend an absolute idealism according to which reality is a unitary, omnipotent, and infinite consciousness playfully manifesting itself in the form of a diverse and external universe (whereas in fact nothing exists outside of this consciousness). This means that they cannot accept any representation of consciousness

as a mirror faithfully reproducing images of the external world: consciousness is not like a mirror because a mirror passively reflects a given, while according to the Śaivas, the essence of consciousness is its dynamism. When imagining an object, for instance, we become aware of, for example, a pot because our consciousness pictures up the pot by taking its form at will. And not only is consciousness capable of thus taking the form of infinitely varied objects: according to whether it focuses on the imagined object or on its own creative activity it can grasp itself in an objective form, as being "the pot," or in a subjective form, as being the consciousness taking the form of the pot ("I am imagining this pot"). The Śaiva nondualists call "realization" (*vimarśa* or *parāmarśa*)[58] this extraordinary ability of consciousness to freely apprehend itself *as being this or that*; and they consider that Śiva manifests the universe by virtue of this very power, that is, by merely *imagining* himself in the form of an external world: the innumerable objects and even the various individuals living and dying in that world are nothing but Śiva *imagining* himself in the form of such limited entities.[59]

The Śaivas therefore emphasize that consciousness is *not* like a mirror in that it does not passively reflect a preexisting and independent universe.[60] Yet they do have recourse to the analogy of phenomena as reflections. This analogy appears in several of Abhinavagupta's works,[61] but Abhinavagupta himself specifies that its source is Utpaladeva's Pratyabhijñā treatise[62]; and indeed, it occurs in this work as Utpaladeva emphasizes that consciousness is capable of manifesting diversity while remaining unitary,[63] just as a mirror can show multiple reflections without being shattered.[64] While commenting on this passage, Abhinavagupta explains:

> And [the reflected objects] such as the mountain do not occur in the mirror in the way [illusory appearances] such as silver or a double moon [occur, i.e.] by concealing the nature of the [real] mother-of-pearl or single moon; for when such a manifestation of the mirror [bearing reflections occurs], the very fact that [the object in front of us] is a mirror is all the more obvious, since [we then] think: "this is a stainless, an excellent, a pure mirror!" For the mountain that is external [to the mirror] does not *enter* the mirror, since [if it were the case, then] as a consequence this [external mountain] would leave its own place[, which is absurd]; nor is the [mountain] manifest *on* the surface of the [mirror], since [if it were the case, then] as a consequence the mirror would not be manifest [as it would be hidden by the mountain]; nor is [the mountain manifest] *inside* [this mirror, since] the nature [of the mirror] is dense, solid and resistant, so that there is no possibility of penetrating it; nor [is it manifested] *behind* [the mirror,] since [we] do not see [it] there[, behind the mirror], and since it is manifested only as being distant [from the mirror and not right behind it]. Nor do the visual rays, being diverted [from the mirror] because upon reaching it they have bounced back, grasp the mountain itself, since when a mirror located on the side of a mountain manifests [a reflection of the mountain, we can] see *both* the reflected [object] and its reflection.[65]

The passage is important because it shows what reflections (and therefore phenomena) are *not* according to the Śaivas.

First of all, we cannot hold that they are pure and simple illusions because they are not false appearances *concealing* reality. Error is defined by the Śaivas as an incomplete manifestation (*apūrṇakhyāti*), and indeed, when we mistake mother-of-pearl for silver due to their common property of glittering, we fail to grasp the existence of mother-of-pearl as long as we are convinced that what we see is silver; similarly, when we see two moons instead of one due to some malfunction of our visual organ, we remain unaware of the single moon as long as we believe that there are two moons in the sky. But in the case at hand, nothing remains veiled or unmanifest. Reflections do not prevent us from being aware of the mirror's presence; in fact they even lead us to realize that the surface on which they appear is indeed a mirror, because when seeing a reflection we understand that *it is only a reflection*, and we do not surmise that the reflected object itself has somehow entered the mirror: we know that we are only contemplating an image of this object, and while apprehending this image we remain conscious of the mirror's presence. The argument already appeared in Utpaladeva's lost commentary on his own verses[66] (along with a criticism of the objection that reflections cannot be real because of the contradiction between their place and size and that of the corresponding reflected object)[67]; it is also found in later Śaiva literature.[68]

But Abhinavagupta also argues that reflections cannot be reduced to the reflected objects themselves: the thesis that visual rays are diverted upon reaching the surface of mirrors and thus come into direct contact with the object that they reflect is not sound because in some cases we can grasp simultaneously the reflected object and its reflection in the mirror. In the TĀ, Abhinavagupta criticizes the same position by saying that if we really perceive thanks to a visual organ capable of leaving our body to touch distant objects, then mirrors should be useless,[69] and we should be aware of perceiving our face itself rather than an image of it in a mirror.[70]

Who is thus targeted by Abhinavagupta? In the ĪPVV, when mentioning the argument that reflections must be illusions because of the contradiction affecting their place and size, Abhinavagupta's opponent invokes Bhartṛhari's authority[71]; but Bhartṛhari does not seem to have concerned himself with the ontological status of reflections,[72] and the rest of the discussion in the ĪPVV shows that the thesis that reflections are mere illusions is rather defended by a Buddhist.[73] Abhinavagupta obviously has in mind arguments of the type formulated by Vasubandhu and Śāntarakṣita, and the passage could even be read as a pastiche of these authors when they try to show that reflections are illusions because reflected objects are seen as possessed of properties that cannot belong to them: according to Abhinavagupta, reflections are not illusions precisely because we are immediately aware, upon seeing a mirror, that what we see *is not the object itself having penetrated the mirror's surface*, but something else that has an existence of its own.

As for the thesis that visual rays bounce back, while commenting on Abhinavagupta's TĀ, Jayaratha (thirteenth century CE) ascribes it to some Naiyāyikas[74] whom he deems "whimsical" since even in the Nyāya their position was far from being unanimously shared, and seems to have been ignored in particular by his Kashmiri fellow countrymen.[75] There are indeed good reasons to think that in these passages Abhinavagupta

targets the Naiyāyikas Pakṣilasvāmin and Uddyotakara: as seen above, their works (which Abhinavagupta knew)[76] defend an explanation of optical reflection very similar to the thesis criticized here. Besides, the Śaiva nondualists argue at length that reflecting objects are characterized by a property called limpidity (*nairmalya* or *svacchatā*) which consists in a power of manifesting other things while manifesting itself,[77] and which, in its purest form, only belongs to consciousness[78]; and this theory is certainly a response to the Naiyāyikas' definition of limpidity as a purely material property,[79] which, according to the Śaivas, results from a confusion between limpidity and resistance (the latter belonging to all material bodies and having nothing to do with the ability to reflect).[80]

It is nonetheless possible and even probable that Abhinavagupta was not exclusively targeting the Naiyāyikas. Thus Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta very likely knew Śāntarakṣita's TS (or at least the Buddhist arguments formulated in this work against the Mīmāṃsā's main theses)[81] so that they were certainly aware of the debate on reflections between Vijñānavādins and Mīmāṃsakas and of its implications regarding the status of phenomena.

Finally, Abhinavagupta could be alluding here to the Advaita Vedānta's position regarding reflections. Determining whether this is likely is an arduous task though. Many a fanciful story links Abhinavagupta with Śaṅkara; thus the Vedāntin is said to have died of an ulcerous disease as a result of a curse by Abhinavagupta, who in turn purportedly died of the same disease transferred back to him by Śaṅkara's pupil Padmapāda.[82] But finding scientific evidence of a relationship between Śaiva nondualism and Vedāntic literature proves particularly difficult. Since Śaiva dualists as well as nondualist predecessors of Utpaladeva were undoubtedly acquainted with Vedāntic doctrines,[83] there is no reason to think that Utpaladeva and his commentator were ignorant of them. But most of the time Vedāntic theories are conspicuously absent in the Pratyabhijñā treatise:[84] it is as though Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta had felt that strategically speaking, targeting such prestigious and well-established rivals as the Buddhist epistemologists or the Naiyāyikas and Mīmāṃsakas should be much more rewarding than discussing with proponents of Advaita Vedānta. One important clue with respect to this debate on reflections is the fact that at least one later Śaiva author, namely, Maheśvarānanda (fourteenth century CE?), sees it first and foremost as a discussion with Vedāntins.[85] However, Śaiva nondualism seems to have been progressively affected by what we might call a "vedānticization" and it has been noted that the originality of the Pratyabhijñā texts was sometimes lost by later commentators projecting onto them the monistic ontology of Advaita Vedānta[86]: it is quite possible that the same tendency affects Maheśvarānanda's understanding of this debate. Nonetheless, Utpaladeva's master, Somānanda (900–950 CE?), already mentions a Vedāntic theory according to which the phenomenal world with all its differences is a manifestation "as a reflection" of the unitary Brahman.[87] It seems very unlikely that Utpaladeva, who has authored a commentary on Somānanda's ŚD,[88] was unaware of the Vedāntins' position in this debate, all the more since the only important debate with Vedāntins in the whole Pratyabhijñā treatise occurs precisely in the verse following that devoted to the discussion on reflections, and revolves around the ontological status of the differences pervading the phenomenal world (which, Utpaladeva argues, cannot be considered

illusory or contradictory with the unitary nature of the absolute consciousness).[89] So although it is unclear which Vedāntic work Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta might have in mind,[90] we can safely assume that in this debate they are taking into account not only the thesis held by the Naiyāyikas, Mīmāṃsakas, and Vijñānavādins, but also that of the Vedāntins.[91]

The Śaivas' "teaching of the mirror": phenomena as reflections without a reflected universe

To sum up, when discussing the nature of reflections or comparing phenomena with reflections, Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta have in mind several rival theories that we must take into account if we wish to understand the Śaivas' position. They reject the Naiyāyikas' and Mīmāṃsakas' view that just as reflections (which are supposedly nothing but objects external to the reflecting entity), phenomena are aspects belonging to a reality external to, and independent of, consciousness. However, while they share with the Vijñānavādins the idea that nothing exists apart from consciousness, and with the Vedāntins the belief that the ultimate reality is unitary, they refuse to admit with both interlocutors that reflections and phenomena are illusory appearances. According to the Śaivas, reflections, just as the differentiated universe of our perceptions, exist in some way that cannot be denied on the mere grounds that the ultimate reality is consciousness (as the Vijñānavādins contend) or that it must be purely unitary (as the Vedāntins argue). But then what are reflections according to the Śaivas, and in what way can the perceived world be compared to them?

The answer to that question is that in the Pratyabhijñā system, reflections cannot be reduced to illusory appearances because they are various ways for the mirror—which is real, and the essence of which is precisely to manifest itself in a variety of ways—of manifesting itself; but for this very reason, they have no *autonomous* existence. Reflections only exist insofar as mirrors manifest them, and this *absolute ontological dependence* constitutes their specificity.[92] Abhinavagupta explains (here again, while relying on Utpaladeva's lost *Vivṛti*)[93] that this is precisely why there is a point in comparing phenomena with reflections:

> Just as reflections are manifest [only] while adhering to the [surface of the] mirror, but do not exist by themselves, regardless of their identity with the mirror, in the same way, it is while adhering to the manifesting [consciousness, i.e.] while being entirely dependent on it—that the [various perceived objects] such as the pot are manifest; [but] they do not exist by themselves.[94]

Reflections are real, and yet they are only real inasmuch as they belong to the mirror from which they seem to be distinct[95]; they appear to be distinct from the mirror, and yet they can be manifest only because they are fundamentally one with the mirror.[96] Similarly, perceived objects only exist insofar as consciousness takes on their form, and they too seem distinct from consciousness (to be aware of an object in front of

us is to apprehend the presence of something external to us), but they can only seem so because our consciousness manifests them *by manifesting itself as if it were distinct from itself* (our consciousness of the external pot is our consciousness taking on the form of a pot external to consciousness).[97]

Admittedly, there is something strikingly odd about this comparison of consciousness with a mirror in an idealistic system, since reflections do not only depend on the existence of a reflecting surface but also on the presence of an object external to that reflecting surface. The Śaivas systematically downplay this aspect of the problem.[98] They are able to do so because they have shown that consciousness cannot be compared to a mirror reflecting external entities (for the simple reason that the distinction between "inside" and "outside" becomes meaningless when it comes to consciousness),[99] but also because as shown above, they subject the Naiyāyika notion of limpidity to a complete conceptual metamorphosis. In the Pratyabhijñā system, the characteristic of reflecting entities becomes the capacity to manifest oneself as something else while remaining oneself (which is the very essence of consciousness according to the Śaivas). This profoundly transforms the meaning of the mirror analogy, since *it is no longer consciousness that is seen as functioning like a mirror* (while the latter requires an external entity of which it produces an image): rather, *mirrors are to some extent comparable to consciousness*, and the fact that mirrors need an external reality to produce reflections is no longer a defining feature of the act of reflecting, but only a sign that mirrors do not possess in full the ability to reflect—mirrors are not mirrors enough when compared to consciousness.

The Śaivas' "teaching of the mirror"[100] is thus meant as a way to point out the infinite plasticity of consciousness: it is first and foremost an invitation to recover one's identity with Śiva by systematically recognizing phenomena as limited aspects that the absolute consciousness freely takes on. For although Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta insist that reflections are not illusions (because we are usually aware that they are only reflections), they also compare the mistake of ordinary individuals—who have lost the awareness of their identity with the unitary and all-encompassing consciousness—with that of somebody who, in some particular circumstances, would cease to be aware that what (s)he sees is a mere reflection in a mirror: the ordinary subjects are metaphysically deluded precisely insofar as they do not realize that the various perceived objects (including those that they wrongly consider as themselves, such as, e.g., their bodies) are in fact nothing but reflections in consciousness, that is, ways for consciousness of manifesting itself as what it is not.[101] According to the Śaivas, however, such an illusion is possible only because the absolute consciousness never really loses the awareness that phenomena are nothing but reflections, just as, when we are daydreaming, for instance, we can get momentarily engrossed in our fantasies, but only because somehow we always remain aware that it is just a fantasy.[102]

In the Śaiva nondualistic perspective the goal of the mirror analogy is therefore to enable us to realize our identity with the absolute consciousness by making us pay attention to the freedom of consciousness involved in any ordinary perception:[103] against the Vedāntins, the Śaiva nondualists refuse to discard the phenomenal world as an illusory appearance, explaining that phenomena can reveal the

power of consciousness, just as, upon realizing that we are seeing a reflection, we become aware of the power of the surface bearing them. Abhinavagupta even playfully reverts the Vedāntins' use of the mirror analogy (i.e., the idea that phenomenal differences are only adventitious properties that do not belong to reality, just as a face reflected on various surfaces can show multiple distortions that do not really affect it)[104] to point out that phenomena, insofar as they are manifestations of consciousness, must be pervaded with the power of freely manifesting oneself that characterizes consciousness:

> And just as a smell, a visual form, tactile sensation, taste and so on,[105] when reflected, are manifest while having their appearance affected by [the properties] of their [reflecting] support, as [in the case of] e.g. a face [reflected] in a sword, in the same way, this [entire] universe, which is reflected in consciousness, must receive all [its] properties: being a manifesting entity, being autonomous, etc.[106]

So this mirror analogy is primarily used by the Śaivas as a soteriological device. Yet it is pervaded with polemical concerns. The previous pages have certainly given the reader a glimpse of the many difficulties and uncertainties involved in any attempt to outline the various positions against which this analogy was designed. Hopefully, however, they have also contributed to show that, because Indian concepts were elaborated in a constant dialogue between rival currents, our best chance to understand them is to try and replace them in their proper philosophical context. This is a difficult task, but also an exciting one, and much remains to be done in this respect—particularly as regards the Śaiva philosophical corpus.

Notes

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1. Preisendanz (1989, pp. 143–146).
2. That is, the ĪPK, a series of verses on which Utpaladeva himself has written two commentaries: a short *Vṛtti* (on which, see Torella [2002]) and a more detailed *Vivṛti* of which only fragments are available to date (see Torella, 1988, 2007a, b, c, and d; Kawajiri, 2016; and Ratié 2016a, b and c).
3. The discussion on the nature of reflections appears in both of Abhinavagupta's commentaries (the ĪPV and ĪPVV) on ĪPK 2.4.19 and was certainly the main topic of Utpaladeva's lost *Vivṛti* ad loc.
4. See, for example, Maheśvarānanda's MMP (written around 1300 CE?), pp. 153–160; cf. the SDS, a fourteenth-century doxographical work according to which in the Pratyabhijñā system, Śiva "manifests the [objective] entities in the mirror of his Self, like reflections" (*svātmadarpaṇe bhāvān pratibimbavad avabhāsayati*) (p. 190).
5. Although in TĀV, vol. II, pp. 26–27, Jayaratha mentions a few scriptural passages conveying (or seeming to convey) the idea that phenomena are similar to reflections, this mirror analogy appears to be a largely post-scriptural phenomenon within the Śaiva corpus.

6. See, for example, Rastogi (1984, pp. 28–31), Lawrence (2005), Ratié (2011a, pp. 273–289), Padoux and Ratié (2013), and Kaul (forthcoming).
7. Thus Rastogi (1984, p. 28), states that Abhinavagupta "follows … Utpala in using this analogy but with added dimensions" (without specifying the nature of these added dimensions). Similarly, while conceding that Utpaladeva makes use of this analogy, Lawrence (2005, p. 586) adds that "nevertheless, Utpaladeva does not thematize reflection as a basic theoretical and practical approach to the Ultimate Reality" while "it is Abhinavagupta who may be credited with making the metaphor of reflection into a favored trope of monistic Śaiva theological discourse."
8. See in particular nn. 62, 64, 66, 67, and 93 below.
9. See, for example, Frauwallner (1962a, p. 22), Sanderson (1985, p. 203; 1988, p. 694), Torella (2002, p. xiii), and Ratié (2011a, pp. 6–14).
10. On the profound influence of the Buddhist philosophical traditions on Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta, see, for example, Torella (1992), Ratié (2010a, 2011b, 2014a and 2016a and b), and McCrea (2016).
11. It is quoted, for example, in ĪPVV, vol. II, p. 225 (= AKBh on AK 2.24, p. 54); vol. II, p. 227 (= AK 2.50a); vol. III, p. 191 (= AK 5.48b); see also the allusion in ĪPVV, vol. I, p. 175 (*abhidharmādau . . .*).
12. On this debate, see, for example, Cox (1988, pp. 53–55).
13. On the context of this passage (a discussion of the Buddhist notion of intermediate existence, *antarābhava*, between the moment of death and that of rebirth), see Kritzer (2000, particularly pp. 243–247) and Fukuda (2003, p. 261).
14. See AKBh, p. 120: *kathaṃ tāvad asiddham—sahaikatra dvayābhāvāt. tatraiva hi deśa ādarśarūpaṃ dṛśyate pratibimbaṃ ca, na caikatra deśe rūpadvayasyāsti sahabhāva āśrayabhūtabhedāt.* "To begin with, how [can we claim that the existence of the reflection] is not established? [It is the case] because two [things] cannot exist together in the same [place]. For [we] see the form of the mirror and the reflection in the same place; but two forms cannot exist together in the same place, because the elements that [constitute their] substrates must be different[, otherwise they would be the same thing]."
15. AKBh, p. 120: *tathā digbhedavyavasthitair* ekasmin vāpyambudeśe svābhimukha-deśasthānāṃ rūpāṇām anyonyaṃ pratibimbakam upalabhyate na tv ekatra rūpe dvayoḥ paśyatoḥ sahadarśanaṃ na bhavatīti na tatra rūpāntaropapattir yuktā.* [**digbhedavyavasthitair* AKVy: *digbhedavyavasthiter* AKBh.] "In the same way, several [observers] located in different places [around a pond] perceive in the same water of the pond a reflection of the other [observers'] forms that are found in the places faced by each [observer]; yet two observers must simultaneously see [the same thing] in the same form[, which is not the case here]; so the existence of a form distinct [from the water, i.e. the reflection], cannot be legitimate[ly said to exist] in the [water]."
16. AKBh, pp. 120–121: *chāyātapayoś ca dvayoḥ sahaikatra bhāvo na dṛṣṭaḥ. upalabhyate ca chāyāstha ādarśe sūryasya pratibimbakam iti na yukto'sya tatra prādurbhāvaḥ.* "Moreover, [we] do not see that these two [things,] shade and sunlight, [can] exist in the same [place]; and [yet we] perceive the reflection of the sun in a mirror located in the shade—so the arising of the [reflection of the sun] in the [mirror] cannot be rationally justified."
17. AKBh, p. 121: *anyatraiva hi deśa ādarśatalaṃ bhavaty anyatraivāntaragataṃ candrapratibimbakaṃ dṛśyate kūpa ivodakam. tac ca tatrotpadyamānaṃ* nānyatropalabhyeta**.* [**tatrotpadyamānaṃ* AKVy: *tatropapadyamānaṃ* AKBh. ***nānyatropalabhyeta* AKVy: *nānyatropalabhyate* AKBh.] "[Or again, the reflection

does not exist] because the surface of the mirror exists in one particular place, [whereas we] perceive the reflection of the moon as being located in another place, [i.e. deep] inside [the mirror], just as water in a well [that we perceive as being at the bottom of the well and not on its surface]. And this [reflection, if it really] arose there[, on the surface of the mirror,] would not be perceived elsewhere[, beyond this surface.]"

18. Cf. AKBh, p. 120: *pratibimbaṃ nāmānyad evotpadyate dharmāntaram ity asiddham etat*. "[The existence of the reflection is not established, i.e.] it is not established that what [we] call a 'reflection' arises while being distinct, [i.e., as] a distinct entity."
19. See AKBh, p. 121: *ato nāsty eva tat kiṃcit. sāmagryās tu sa tasyās tādṛśaḥ prabhāvo yat tathā darśanaṃ bhavati, acintyo hi dharmāṇāṃ śaktibhedaḥ.* "As a consequence this [reflection] is nothing at all that would exist; but the power of the causal complex (*sāmagrī*) is such that it produces an appearance of this sort, for entities have a diversity of powers that cannot be fathomed (*acintya*)." Kritzer (2002) shows that here as elsewhere in the AKBh, Vasubandhu uses the term "*acintya*" as a hint that this cannot be explained by the orthodox Sarvāstivādin doctrine (according to which reflections are real).
20. See, for example, NVTṬ, p. 485: *…prasaṅgāt pratibimbabhramotpādakramam āha …* "[Uddyotakara] explains as a consequence [of the point just discussed] the process through which the illusions that are reflections arise."
21. On this theory, see, for example, Frauwallner ([1956] 1973, pp. 29–33) and Preisendanz (1989); on its criticism by Buddhist authors, see, for example, Hattori (1968, pp. 36–37 and 124–126).
22. See NBh, p. 161: *yathādarśe pratihatasya parāvṛttasya nayanaraśmeḥ svena mukhena sannikarṣe sati svamukhopalambhanaṃ pratibimbagrahaṇākhyam… bhavati.* "For example, in a mirror, when the visual rays, being diverted [and] bouncing back, come into contact with [our] own face, there occurs a perception that [we usually] call the 'apprehension of a reflection' [although in fact it is a perception of our] own face…" (Following Preisendanz (1989, fn. 31, p. 148), I understand *raśmi* in the singular as referring to a "bundle of single rays.")
23. See NV, pp. 362–363 : … *prasādasvabhāvatvād ādarśodakādiṣu nayanaraśmiḥ pratihanyate. sa ca pratihataḥ pratinivṛtya svamukhādinā sambadhyate. tasya cāgrasambandhād yad abhimukham agraṃ tad abhimukhaṃ mukhādi paśyatīti yathāgrato vyavasthitasya puruṣasyeti. ādarśamukhagrahaṇaṃ tu krameṇa bhavad apy āśubhāvān na vibhāvyate.* "In such [things] as a mirror or water, because [their] nature is limpidity, the visual rays are diverted. And when the [visual rays] that are diverted bounce back, they come into contact with e.g. one's own face. And because [in this process they] come into contact with what[ever is] in front [of the mirror], they see what[ever] is in front, such as a face; for instance [they see the face] of the man standing in front [of the mirror]. But although the apprehension of the face and [that of] the mirror occur one after the other, due to the speed [of this process] it does not appear [to be so]."
24. On the Mīmāṃsakas' defense of the Nyāya thesis that visual rays emanate from the eyes and come into contact with the object, see, for example, Bhatt (1962, pp. 174–177) and Taber (2005, pp. 58–64).
25. It is not identical however (as far as I understand it): whereas according to the Naiyāyikas, the visual rays bounce back because the mirror's surface is endowed with a particular property called *prasāda* ("limpidity," on which see n. 79 below), according to the Mīmāṃsakas, it is a light ray on the mirror's surface which is responsible for the visual ray bouncing back (see below, nn. 26, 28, and 53).

26. See, for example, ŚV, *Śabdanityatādhikaraṇa* 180cd–181ac: *atra brūmo yadā tāvaj jale saureṇa tejasā // sphuratā cākṣuṣaṃ tejaḥ pratisrotaḥ pravartitam / svadeśa eva gṛhṇāti savitāram* … "To this [objection] we reply [the following]: to begin with, when a sunray shining on water makes the visual ray bounce back, [what this visual ray] grasps is the sun [existing] in its own place [i.e., the sky]."
27. See *Śāstradīpikā*, p. 399: *nanu pratibimbaṃ nāmārthāntaraṃ tatra dṛśyate. na, tasyābhāvād anupalambhāc ca, na hi mūrtamadhye mūrtāntaraṃ sambhavati. kiṃ ca śarāvastham udakaṃ bhūmer upari nābhidaghne dhārayitvā tasyopariṣṭād aratnidaghne svamukhaṃ kurvann udakasyādhastād aratnimātre mukhapratibimbaṃ paśyati, tasmiṃś ca deśe pārśvasthāḥ puruṣā na kiṃcid api paśyanti tena dṛśyādarśananirastaḥ pratibimbākhyo'rtho na śakyo'bhyupagantum.* "[– Objection :] But in the [case when something is reflected in a mirror or water, we] perceive [something] called 'reflection' which is an object distinct [from the reflected entity. To this we answer]: no, because the [reflection] does not exist and because [we] do not [really] perceive it. For a material [thing] cannot exist within another material [thing]. Besides, [someone] who carries water above the ground in a plate, at the level of his navel, placing his face above the [water] at a maximum distance of one cubit, sees a reflection of his face only within that [distance of one] cubit [and sees it as if it were] under the [surface of the] water, whereas the persons standing on the side do not see anything at that very place [where he sees the reflection]. Therefore [we] cannot admit the [existence of the] thing called 'reflection': [it is] refuted by the fact that [we] do not perceive [it whereas] it should be perceived [if it existed]." Cf. AKBh, p. 120, quoted above, nn. 14, 15, and 17.
28. See *Śāstradīpikā*, pp. 399–400: *tasmād ādarśatejasā jalena ca pratihataṃ nāyaṇaṃ tejaḥ parāvṛttya gṛhṇātīti yuktam.* "Therefore it is right to hold [rather] that the visual rays, which have been diverted by the [light] ray from the mirror and by water and have bounced back, grasp [our very face and not an image of it somewhere else]."
29. Compare, for example, AKBh, p. 121 (quoted above, n. 19) with TS 262ab (quoted below, n. 36) stating that things have diverse "powers" (*śakti*) that "cannot be fathomed" (*acintya*). See also Kamalaśīla's allusion to Vasubandhu's analogy with the water in a well: compare AKBh, p. 121 (quoted above, n. 17) with TSP, vol. I, p. 133 (quoted below, n. 34).
30. See Ratié (2014c, pp. 210–218).
31. See below, nn. 32, 34, and 36. Note that the terms *bhrānti/bhrama* can denote both the illusion understood as the appearance having no correspondence with reality and the cognition apprehending this appearance.
32. See TS 259b–d: … *mūrtānām asahasthiteḥ / bibharti darpaṇatalaṃ naiva chāyāṃ kadācana //* "Because material [objects] cannot exist together [in the same place], the surface of the mirror never bears any reflection at all in any circumstance." Kamalaśīla comments (TSP, vol. I, p. 133): *tathā hi darpaṇatale taddeśāny eva parvatādipratibimbāny upalabhyante, na ca mūrtāḥ padārthāḥ kadācid ekadeśatām āpadyante, aikātmyaprasaṅgāt.* "To explain: on the surface of the mirror, the reflections of e.g. a mountain are perceived as being located precisely in the [place occupied by the mirror]; but material objects cannot share the same place in any [circumstance], because [if they did] as a consequence they would be one and the same [thing]." See also TS 2592: *pratibimbodayas tv atra prāg eva vinivāritaḥ / sahaikatra dvayāyogān mūrtānāṃ pratighātataḥ //* But [we] have already dismissed in this [treatise the possibility] that a reflection might [really] arise, on the grounds that

two [things] cannot exist together in the same [place], because material [objects] offer resistance [to each other]." Cf. Vasubandhu's argument quoted above, n. 14.

33. See TS 260: *pārśvadvitayasaṃsthāś ca suśuklaṃ sphaṭikopalam / samīkṣante* tad eṣo'pi na chāyāṃ pratipannavān //* [**samīkṣante* correction: *samīkṣyante* TS.] "And [those] who stand on both sides [of a piece of crystal that seems red due to the red flower behind it] see that piece of crystal as perfectly colorless; so this [piece of crystal] does not bear any reflection either." Cf. Vasubandhu's argument quoted above, n. 15.
34. See TSP, vol. I, p. 133: *tathā hi kūpāntargatodakavad darpaṇatale pratibimbakam antargatam upalabhyate, na ca darpaṇatalasya vibhāgaḥ—randhram asti nibiḍatarāvayavasanniveśāt, tasmād bhrāntir iyam.* "To explain: on the surface of the mirror, [we] perceive the reflection as being inside [the mirror], just as water [that we perceive as being deep] inside the well [and not on its surface]; but the surface of the mirror is undivided, [says Śāntarakṣita, i.e.] it has no empty space since its parts hold together very tight—so this [arising of the reflection] is an illusion." See also TSP, vol. II, pp. 709–710 (quoted below, n. 39). Cf. Vasubandhu's argument quoted above, n. 17.
35. See TS 258: *sopadhānetarāvastha eka eveti sarvadā / tacchāyas tadviyukto vā sa dṛśyetānyathā punaḥ //* "… Whereas if it were not the case [that a reflecting entity such as a mirror or a crystal is momentary], given that [this entity] would remain one [and the same,] whether in the state where [a blue lotus] is placed [next to it] or in the state where [this blue lotus] is not [placed next to it, as a consequence we] would always see it possessed of this reflection, or [we would always see it] devoid of this reflection!"
36. See TS 261: *bhedaḥ pratyupadhānaṃ ca sphaṭikādeḥ prasajyate / tacchāyāpratipattiś cet tasya vidyeta tāttvikī //* "And there [would] follow that [a reflecting entity] such as a crystal would be different according to each [object] placed [next to it] if this [crystal] really acquired a reflection of the [object placed next to it]." Kamalaśīla explains (TSP, vol. I, p. 133): *yadi hi paramārthataḥ sphaṭikāder upadhānoparāgapratipattir bhavet tadā yathā kramabhāvinīnām upadhānachāyānāṃ svabhāvabhedān naikātmyam, tadvat tadātmanaḥ sphaṭikāder apy upadhānam upadhānaṃ prati pratyupadhānaṃ bhedaḥ prasajyeta. yadi punar bhrāntir iyam ity aṅgīkriyate tadāyam adoṣa iti jñāpanārthaṃ tāttvikīty āha.* "To explain: if the [reflecting entity] such as a crystal really acquired a coloration from the [object] placed [next to it], then just as the [various momentary] reflections arising in succession from the [object] placed [next to the crystal] would not all be the same [reflection] because of the difference between their [respective] natures [existing at different moments], in the same way, there would also follow that [a reflecting entity] such as crystal would be different according to each [object] placed [next to it, since the crystal] would have as its nature these [momentary reflections]. But if [we] admit that this [arising of a reflection in the reflecting entity] is an illusion, then there is no [more] fault—it is in order to convey this [idea] that [Śāntarakṣita] says '[if this crystal] *really* [acquired a reflection]…'" In TS 262ab Śāntarakṣita concludes: *tasmād bhrāntir iyaṃ teṣu vicitrācintyaśaktiṣu /* "Therefore this [arising of a reflection] is an illusion [that occurs] in [the presence of entities] that have diverse powers which cannot be fathomed (*acintya*)." Kamalaśīla explains (TSP, vol. I, p. 133): *yataś caivaṃ pakṣadvaye'pi chāyāpratipattir na yujyate tasmād bhrāntir iyam iti sthitam.* "And since thus, whichever thesis [we choose] among the two [just mentioned concerning the capacity of things to last], acquiring a reflection is impossible, it is [now] established that the [arising of reflections in mirrors, etc.] is an illusion."
37. Kumārila is explicitly presented as Śāntarakṣita's target in several passages of the TS and TSP criticizing the Brahmanical theory of reflections. TS 258–262 (quoted

above, nn. 35 and 36) is part of a critical examination (TS 222–284) of Kumārila's thesis regarding the nature of the Self; and TS 2586–2589 (quoted below, n. 38) is presented by Kamalaśīla as an answer to TS 2223, which is a quotation of ŚV, *Śabdanityatādhikaraṇa* 189cd–190ab (it might as well be a fragment from Kumārila's lost *Bṛhaṭṭīkā*, which, as shown in Frauwallner (1962b), contained a number of verses identical to those found in the ŚV). As for TS 2080, it is part of a discussion with Kumārila on the existence of external objects: it seems to me that Jha (1937, vol. II, p. 986) is wrong in supposing that it answers an objection formulated in the previous verse by "another party" (than the Mīmāṃsaka). In doing so he follows the assumption of the TSP editor, who surmises (TSP, vol. II, p. 709) a euphonic combination (*sandhi*) of the word *aparaḥ* ("another [opponent]") with the preceding compound, but given the context it seems likely that one should rather read *paraḥ*, that is, "the opponent [dealt with so far]" (namely, Kumārila).

38. See TS 2586–2589ac: *pratibimbakavijñānaṃ svāsyādyālambanaṃ na tat / tadvilakṣaṇanirbhāsād rasaśabdādivittivat // alpīyasy āsyam alpīyo darpaṇe pratibhāti hi / viparyastaś ca vṛkṣādir jalamagnaḥ pratīyate // darpaṇābhimukhaṃ bimbaṃ naivaṃ tu pratibimbakam / jalādyantargataṃ cedaṃ bimbaṃ tv ārād avasthitam // āśrayānuvidhānena sthūlasūkṣmādibhedi ca / pratibimbaṃ na bimbaṃ tu …* "The cognition of a reflection does not have as its [objective] support (*ālambana*) e.g. the own face [of the person observing a mirror], because the [objective] appearance [of this cognition] differs from the [face], just as the cognition of e.g. a taste or a sound [differs from the cognition of a visual form]. For the face appears smaller in a smaller mirror; and a tree [on a bank] for instance is apprehended as being upside down [and] immersed in the water [that reflects it]. The reflected object is turned towards the mirror, but the reflection is not; and this [reflection] is e.g. in the water whereas the reflected object stands in the distance; and the reflection is different as regards its being large or minute according to its substrate, whereas this is not the case of the reflected object."

39. See TS 2080: *nābhimukhyena taddṛṣṭeḥ svamukhādes tathekṣaṇam / pramāṇadeśabhedādidṛṣṭeś cānyapadārthavat //* "It is not e.g. [our] own face that [we] see thus [when observing a mirror], because [we] see it in front [of us], and because [we] see it as different [from our face] as regards the size, place and so on, just as when [we see] a [completely] different object." Cf. TSP, vol. II, pp. 709–710: *etad uktaṃ bhavati. yadi mukhādigrāhakaṃ tajjñānaṃ syāt tadā yathaiva tanmukhādi vyavasthitaṃ tathaiva gṛhṇīyāt, na hy anyākārasya jñānasyānyad grāhyaṃ yuktam atiprasaṅgāt, yāvatā dakṣiṇābhimukhasthito darpaṇatalaṃ nibhālayann uttarābhimukhaṃ svamukhaṃ paśyati, tathālpīyasi* darpaṇatale mahato'pi svamukhasyālpapratibimbakam upalabhyate tathā darpaṇatalasambaddhaṃ dūrādhaḥpraviṣṭam ivekṣyate. na ca tāvad bahalaṃ tathādarśatalaṃ nāpi mukhādi tatsambaddham. tathā vimalasalile sarasi taṭāntasthitaśākhiśikhariṇāṃ pratibimbāny adhogataśākhādiśikharaśekharāṇy upalabhyante, na ca te tathā sthitāḥ. tasmāt pratibimbajñānaṃ na svamukhādigrāhakaṃ tadvilakṣaṇapratibhāsitvāc chabdajñānavat.* [**tathālpīyasi* TSPK: *yathālpīyasi* TSP.] "This is what [Śāntarakṣita] means: if the cognition of the [reflection] apprehended e.g. [our own] face, then [we] would apprehend it exactly as our face is; for it is not right [to assume that] a cognition endowed with a particular appearance [of a given object] might have an object different [from that objective appearance], because this would lead to absurd consequences. [But] someone who is facing southwards while observing the surface of the mirror sees his face turned northwards; in the same way, on the surface of a small

mirror, the reflection of his face is apprehended [as being] small although [his face is] big; and again, [the reflected face] is perceived as being in contact with the surface of the mirror [and yet] as if it had penetrated deep underneath [this surface]. Now, to begin with, the surface of the mirror has no such depth; nor is the face or [any other reflected object really] in contact with the [surface]. Similarly, in the clear waters of a lake, [we] perceive the reflections of the tops of the trees standing on the bank of the river[, and in these reflections we see] the [tree] tops as well as the highest parts of the branches bending downwards, whereas they do not exist in this way. For all these reasons, the cognition of the reflection does not apprehend e.g. the own face [of the observer standing in front of the mirror,] because it has an appearance [of object] that differs from the [face itself], just as the cognition of a sound [differs from that of a visual form]."

40. See, for example, Bhatt (1962, pp. 23–25 and 45) and Taber (2010, p. 283).
41. See TS 252: *bhavanmate hi nākāro buddher bāhyas tu varṇyate / na vivakṣitadeśe ca gajavāsyādayaḥ sthitāḥ //* "For in your doctrine, the appearance [of object] does not belong to the cognition: rather, [you] describe it as external [to consciousness]. And [in the case of erroneous cognitions, the objects that we wrongly believe to exist in one place], such as e.g. the elephant [perceived as located] in a blade [reflecting it], do not exist in the place about which [the cognition] is." (On my interpretation of the compound *gajavāsyādayaḥ*, see Ratié [2014c, p. 293, fn. 1053].) Cf. TSP, vol. I, p. 130: *kiṃ ca bhavato mīmāṃsakasya mate yo bhāsamānaḥ sa ākāro na buddheḥ, kintv asau bāhyārthasvabhāvo varṇyate, ākāravān bāhyo'rtho nirākārā buddhir iti vacanāt*. "Moreover, in your doctrine—you Mīmāṃsaka—the [objective] appearance that is manifest [when we perceive] does not belong to the cognition: rather, [you] describe it as having as its nature the external object, since [you] state that the external object possesses an appearance, whereas the cognition is devoid of appearance (*nirākāra*)."
42. Other such contexts include the role of the sense organs in perception (see, e.g., the Nyāya texts quoted above, nn. 20, 22, and 23), the existence of an intermediate state between death and rebirth (as in the case of the AKBh passage quoted here: see above, n. 13) or the nature of speech (see, e.g., Kumārila's thesis quoted above, n. 26).
43. See, for example, Lamotte (1949, vol. I, pp. 357–360) and May (1959, p. 75, fn. 110). On the various uses of the mirror simile in Buddhist literature, see also Wayman (1971 and 1974).
44. See, for example, MMK 23.9cd, according to which all perceptible forms (visual, auditory etc.) are "like an [illusory] person [appearing thanks to some] magic trick, and similar to reflections" (*māyāpuruṣakalpeṣu pratibimbasameṣu ca*). Cf., for example, *Prasannapadā*, p. 295: *niḥsvabhāveṣu sarvabhāveṣu pratibimbamarīcikājalālāta-cakrasvapnamāyendrajālasadṛśeṣu …* "With respect to all things, which are devoid of intrinsic nature, [i.e.] similar to reflections, the water of a mirage, a fire-brand [appearing as] a circle [when moved very fast], a dream, an illusion, a magic trick . . ."
45. As to whether this Buddhist idealism should be understood as simply stating that we cannot have access to any external reality, or rather, as denying the existence of anything outside of consciousness, see, for example, Kellner and Taber (2014); on the Śaivas' view regarding this issue, see Ratié (2014b).
46. On this analogy, see, for example, Taber (1994 and 2010, p. 281); see also Ratié (2010a, pp. 453–460).
47. See, for example, TVBh, p. 126: *tatpṛṣṭhalabdhena jñānena māyāmarīcisvapnapratiśrut-kodakacandranirmitasamān sarvadharmān pratyeti.* "Through the knowledge acquired

subsequently one knows all things to be similar to illusions, mirages, dreams, echos, the moon [reflected] in the water or [fictional] creations." Cf. the remark found in the *Mahāyānasaṅgraha* that the image is meant as a way to explain how karmic law or phenomenal diversity can occur if there is no external object (see Lamotte, 1938, p. 123), or MVBh, p. 66 and MVṬ, p. 220, which specify that the reflection of the moon in the water "exists only [inasmuch as it is] an illusion" (*bhrāntimātrāstitva*). It should be noted that some of these Yogācāra texts invoke the argument (later developed by Naiyāyikas and Mīmāṃsakas!) that reflections do not exist as such because when perceiving a reflection, in fact all we see is the reflected object (see Fukuda [2003, p. 264], on this argument in the *Sandhinirmocanasūtra* and Asaṅga's interpretation of it in the *Mahāyānasaṅgraha*).

48. See Kritzer (2002, pp. 72–73).
49. On this thesis and its presentation by Abhinavagupta, see Ratié (2011b) and McCrea (2016, pp. 266–272).
50. Although these authors belong to the Madhyamaka (see, e.g., Seyfort Ruegg, 1981, pp. 87–93), this affiliation remains mostly implicit in the TS and TSP, where the Vijñānavāda is presented as the highest perspective (see, e.g., McClintock, 2010, pp. 85–91).
51. See the Vijñānavādin's thesis formulated in TS 2078: *vivādāspadam ārūḍhaṃ vijñānatvād ato matam* / advayaṃ vedyakartṛtvaviyogāt pratibimbavat //* [**matam* conjecture: *mataḥ* TS.] "So [we] consider that [the cognition] which constitutes the subject of this debate [i.e., ordinary perception], involves no duality [between consciousness and an external object], since it is devoid of [the duality between] being an object of knowledge and being a [knowing] agent; and this is the case] because [this perception] is a cognition, just as [the cognition] of a reflection."
52. See, for example, the objection (which might come from a Naiyāyika but is more probably to be ascribed to Kumārila: see above, n. 37) put forward in TS 2079 in answer to the Vijñānavādin's thesis: *nanu ca pratibimbe'pi jñānaṃ sālambanaṃ matam / cakṣūraśminivṛttau hi svamukhādes tathekṣaṇāt //* "But even in [the case of] a reflection, [we] consider that the cognition has an [external objective] support; for [it is] because the visual rays bounce back [that we] see e.g. [our] own face thus [i.e., as being inside the mirror]." Cf. TSP, vol. II, p. 709: *yasmān nāyanā raśmayo darpaṇāditalapratihatā nivartamānāḥ svamukhādinā sambadhyante tatas te tathā mukhādipratītihetavo bhavanti. ataḥ svamukhāder eva tathā darpaṇādyantargatādi-rūpeṇekṣaṇaṃ bhavati. tataś ca na pratibimbajñānaṃ grāhyagrāhakadvayarahitaṃ siddham*. "Because the visual rays, when diverted by the surface of [the reflecting entity] such as a mirror, bounce back [and] come into contact with e.g. [our] own face, they are the causes [making us] apprehend e.g. [our own] face thus. Therefore the perception [of the reflection] is [in fact the perception] of e.g. [our] own face itself thus, [i.e.] in a form that is e.g. inside [the reflecting entity] such as the mirror. And therefore [contrary to what you claim, you] have not established that the cognition of a reflection is devoid of the duality of the apprehended object and apprehending subject [since the object of this cognition exists independently of the cognition itself.]"
53. See, for example, *Bhāmatī*, vol. I, p. 21: *evaṃ vijñātṛpuruṣābhimukheṣv ādarśodakādiṣu svaccheṣu cākṣuṣaṃ tejo lagnam api balīyasā sauryeṇa tejasā pratisrotaḥ pravartitaṃ mukhasaṃyuktaṃ mukhaṃ grāhayad, doṣavaśāt taddeśatām anabhimukhatāṃ ca mukhasyāgrāhayat, pūrvadṛṣṭābhimukhādarśodakadeśatām ābhimukhyaṃ ca mukhasyāropayatīti pratibimbavibhramo'pi lakṣito bhavati*. "In the same way, in limpid [reflecting entities] such as a mirror or water [when they] face an observer, the visual

rays, although in contact [with the surface of the mirror or water], are diverted by a stronger sunray, [and] being in contact with the face [itself], they make [us] grasp the face [itself; but] because of a defect [in this process], they do not make [us] grasp where the face is [really] located and the fact that it does not [really] face [us. In other words, in this case they make us] superimpose on the face [the property of] being located in the mirror or water, which face [us] and which [we] have previously seen, and [the property of] facing [us]—therefore this illusion of reflection too complies with the definition [of superimposition just given, according to which one superimposes something previously seen on some other locus]."

54. The Vedāntins seem to have been aware of this paradox. See, for example, BSBh, vol. II, p. 710, highlighting the limits of the analogy in a nondualistic context: *sūryādibhyo hi mūrtebhyaḥ pṛthagbhūtaṃ viprakṛṣṭadeśaṃ mūrtaṃ jalaṃ gṛhyate, tatra yuktaḥ sūryādipratibimbodayaḥ, na tv ātmā mūrto na cāsmāt pṛthagbhūtā viprakṛṣṭadeśāś copādhayaḥ, sarvagatatvāt sarvānanyatvāc ca.* "For water is grasped [as being] a material [thing] distinct from [other] material [things] such as the sun, [and] located in a place distant [from them]; [and] a reflection of e.g. the sun can arise on [the surface of] that [water]. But the Self is not material and the adventitious properties are not distinct from it and located in a place distant [from it], because [the Self] is omnipresent and not different from anything." Śaṅkara points out that the analogy is nonetheless valid because analogies do not require a complete similarity (*sarvasārūpya*) of the two relata involved (ibid.: *yukta eva tv ayaṃ dṛṣṭānto vivakṣitāṃśasambhavāt* . . . "However, this analogy is valid, because [an analogy] can be [only] partly relevant . . .").
55. They also had frequent recourse to the analogy of reflections in a mirror to explain, for example, the problematic relationship between the Brahman and the individual souls (*jīva*).
56. See, for example, BSBh, vol. II, p. 710: *jalagataṃ hi sūryapratibimbaṃ jalavṛddhau vardhate jalahrāse hrasati jalacalane calati jalabhede bhidyata ity evaṃ jaladharmānuyāyi bhavati, na tu paramārthataḥ sūryasya tathātvam asti. evaṃ paramārtho'vikṛtam ekarūpam api sad brahma dehādyupādhyantarbhāvād bhajata ivopādhidharmān vṛddhihrāsādīn.* "For the reflection of the sun which is in the water gets larger when the [surface of the] water is larger, gets smaller when the [surface of the] water gets smaller, trembles when the [surface of the] water trembles, is scattered [into different parts] when [the surface of the] water is scattered—thus [this reflection] conforms to the properties of the water, but in reality the sun does not exist in such a way. Similarly, the Brahman, which in reality remains unchanged, seems to possess adventitious properties such as getting larger and smaller, etc., although in fact it is unitary, because of its being concealed by such adventitious properties as the body, etc."
57. See, for example, BSi, p. 72: *api ca bhedatvād eva viśvasya bhedo'bhedopādāna iti śakyate'numātum. dṛṣṭo hi maṇikṛpāṇadarpaṇādiṣv abhinnamukhopādānas tadbhedaḥ.* "Morover, [we] can [legitimately] infer that the universe's difference, precisely because it is a difference, has as its basis nondifference. For the difference [affecting] a [face reflected] in jewels, swords, mirrors and so on has as its basis the unitary face [thus reflected]." Cf. *Tattvasamīkṣā* ad loc., p. 133: *yo yo'bhedaḥ sa sarva īdṛśaḥ, yathā bimbābhedopādānaḥ pratibimbānāṃ bheda iti.* "All nondifference is such [that it is the basis from which we conceptualize difference,] just as the difference of [various] reflections [of a single object] has as its basis the unity of the reflected object."

58. On this important Śaiva notion (interpreted and translated in sometimes strikingly different ways), see, for example, Alper (1987, pp. 188 ff.), Torella (2002, pp. xxiii–xxv), and Ratié (2011a, pp. 158–162).
59. On Utpaladeva's thesis that imagination is a free creativity and that as such it constitutes the essence of consciousness, see Ratié (2010b).
60. See in particular ĪPK 1.5.11: *svabhāvam avabhāsasya vimarśaṃ vidur anyathā / prakāśo'rthoparakto'pi sphaṭikādijaḍopamaḥ //* "[The wise] know that the nature of [conscious] manifestation is realization (*vimarśa*): if this were not the case, although the manifesting [consciousness] would have its appearance affected (*uparakta*) by the object, it would be similar to an insentient [reflecting entity] such as a crystal." See Torella (2002, p. 118). In his commentaries, Abhinavagupta insists that while such objects as a crystal can manifest other objects by bearing their reflection, they remain insentient, contrary to consciousness, precisely because they are not capable of realization. See ĪPV, vol. I, pp. 197–198 (as edited in Ratié [2011a, pp. 501–502]): *athānyenāpi satā ghaṭena yato'vabhāsasya pratibimbarūpā cchāyā dattā, tām asāv avabhāso bibhrad ghaṭasyety ucyate, tataś cājaḍaḥ, tarhi sphaṭikasalilamakurādir apy evambhūta evety ajaḍa eva syāt. atha tathābhūtam apy ātmānaṃ taṃ ca ghaṭādikaṃ sphaṭikādir na parāmraṣṭuṃ samartha iti jaḍas tathāparāmarśanam eva tarhy ajāḍyajīvitam antarbahiṣkaraṇasvātantryarūpaṃ svābhāvikam avabhāsasya …* "If [you say that] the pot, while being distinct [from its manifestation within consciousness], provides this manifestation with an appearance consisting in a reflection (*pratibimba*), [and if you add] that the manifestation bearing this [reflection] is what [we] call [the manifestation] of the pot, and that it is for this reason that [this manifestation] is sentient—then [all reflecting objects] as well, such as a crystal, water or a mirror, must necessarily be sentient since they are perfectly similar [to consciousness as you have just described it]! If [you reply] that [reflecting objects] such as a crystal are insentient because although they thus [bear a reflection of the object], they are unable to produce a realization (*parāmṛś-*) either of themselves or of the [reflected objects] such as a pot, then [we must conclude that] it is such a realization, which is the [very] life of sentiency, [and] which consists in freedom with respect to the internal and external sense organs, that is essential to [conscious] manifestation …" On this famous passage see, for example, Alper (1987) and Ratié (2011a, pp. 495–507).
61. See the long passage on reflections in TĀ 3, or PS 12–13: *darpaṇabimbe yadvan nagaragrāmādi citram avibhāgi / bhāti vibhāgenaiva ca parasparaṃ darpaṇād api ca // vimalatamaparamabhairavabodhāt tadvad vibhāgaśūnyam api / anyonyaṃ ca tato'pi ca vibhaktam ābhāti jagad etat //* "Just as, in the orb of a mirror, the variety of e.g. a city or a village is manifest as if it were distinct [both] with respect to its own [components] and with respect to the mirror, [although in fact] it involves no [such] distinction; in the same way, this universe is manifest [as being] distinct [both] with respect to its own [parts] and with respect to the absolutely limpid consciousness that is the Supreme Bhairava, although [in fact] it involves no [such] distinction." See Bansat-Boudon and Tripathi (2011, pp. 112–117).
62. See TĀ 3.8, where Abhinavagupta defines the property called limpidity that makes the manifestation of reflections possible: *svasminn abhedād bhinnasya darśanakṣamataiva yā / atyaktasvaprakāśasya nairmalyaṃ tad gurūditam //* "Limpidity is nothing but the capacity of [an entity such as a mirror] to manifest in oneself [a reflection that is apparently] distinct while not ceasing to manifest oneself[; and is possible] because [the reflecting entity actually remains] one [with the reflection]: this has

been said by the Master." Cf. TĀV, vol. II, p. 10: *gurūditam iti guruṇā paramaguruṇā śrīmadutpaladevenāthārthasya yathārūpam ity ādi, tathā na ca yuktaṃ jaḍasyaivam ity ādi śrīpratyabhijñākārikādvayaṭīkāyām etan nikhilam eva pratibimbasatattvam uditam uktam ity arthaḥ.* "'[This has been] said by the Master', [i.e.] by the master of [Abhinavagupta's] master [namely] the venerable Utpaladeva [in ĪPK 1.2.8—a verse] which begins with [the words] *athārthasya yathārūpam* …—and [in ĪPK 2.4.19—a verse] which begins with [the words] *na ca yuktaṃ jaḍasyaivam* … This nature of reflections has been exhaustively (*nikhilam eva*) explained in [Utpaladeva's] detailed commentary (*ṭīkā*) on these two verses from the Pratyabhijñā [treatise]—this is [what Abhinavagupta] means [here]." The commentary alluded to by Jayaratha is Utpaladeva's lost *Vivṛti*; as for ĪPK 1.2.8, it has to do with a rather different debate on the relationship between the intellect and consciousness in Sāṃkhya (on this debate, see Ratié [2011a, pp. 94–106 and 276–280]).

63. See ĪPK 2.4.19: *na ca yuktaṃ jaḍasyaivaṃ bhedābhedavirodhataḥ / ābhāsabhedād ekatra cidātmani tu yujyate //* "And [agency defined] in this way [as a capacity to transform oneself] cannot belong to an insentient [entity], because [if it were the case] there would be a contradiction between difference and identity, since [transformation involves] a difference between [various] manifestations; whereas [such an agency] is possible in the unitary [entity] that has consciousness as its essence." See Torella (2002, p. 186).
64. The analogy, which was certainly stated at length in Utpaladeva's lost *Vivṛti* (see above, n. 62 and below, n. 93), also appears in his *Vṛtti*, p. 60: *jaḍasyābhinnātmano bhedenāvasthiter virodhād ayuktam, svacche cidātmany ekasminn evam anekapratibimbadhāraṇenāvirodhād yujyate.* "[Agency] cannot [belong to an insentient entity] because [if it were the case] there would be a contradiction between the unitary essence of the insentient [entity] and the differentiated existence [that transformation involves. However,] it is possible in a limpid (*svaccha*) unitary [entity] that has consciousness as its essence, because in this case there is no contradiction [between its unity and] its bearing various reflections." See Torella (2002, p. 186). Abhinavagupta explains that while an ordinary object cannot change without ceasing to be itself (a triangle that would cease to have three angles would cease to exist), consciousness, like a mirror, is capable of manifesting itself in different ways while remaining itself. See, for example, ĪPV, vol. II, p. 177 (as edited in Ratié [forthcoming]): *yat tu prameyadaśāpatitaṃ na bhavati kiṃ tu cidrūpatayā prakāśaparamārtharūpaṃ cidekasvabhāvaṃ svacchaṃ tatra bhedābhedarūpatopapadyate. anubhavād eva hi svacchasyādarśāder akhaṇḍitasvasvabhāvasyaiva parvatamataṅgajādirūpasahasrasambhinnaṃ vapur upalabhyate.* "However, having [both of these] forms[, i.e.,] differentiation and undifferentiation, is possible in that which has not fallen into the state of an object of knowledge, but rather, is limpid (*svaccha*) [because] its nature is one with consciousness—[i.e., in that which] consists in the ultimate reality that is the manifesting entity (*prakāśa*) because its nature is consciousness (*cit*). For it is through [immediate] experience that [we] perceive the form of a limpid [reflecting entity] such as a mirror as divided into countless [various] forms—a mountain, an elephant and so on—whereas its own nature remains intact."
65. ĪPV, vol. II, pp. 177–178 (as edited in Ratié [forthcoming]): *na ca rajatadvicandrādi yathā śuktikaikacandrasvarūpatirodhānena vartate tathā darpaṇe parvatādi, darpaṇasya hi tathāvabhāse darpaṇataiva sutarām unmīlati nirmalo'yam utkṛṣṭo'yaṃ śuddho'yaṃ darpaṇa ity abhimānāt. na hi parvato bāhyas tatra saṅkrāmati svadeśatyāgaprasaṅgād asya, na cāsya pṛṣṭhe'sau bhāti darpaṇānavabhāsaprasaṅgāt, na ca madhye nibiḍakaṭhinasapratighasvabhāvasya tatrānupraveśasambhāvanābhāvāt,*

na paścāt tatrādarśanād dūratayaiva ca bhāsanāt, na ca tannipatanotphalitapratyāvṛttāś cākṣuṣā mayūkhāḥ parvatam eva gṛhṇanti, bimbapratibimbayor ubhayor api parvatapārśvagatadarpaṇāvabhāse'valokanāt.

66. See ĪPVV, vol. III, p. 242: *akhyātir eva cāpūrṇakhyātimayī bhrāntes tattvam ity upapāditam eva, prakṛte tu nākhyātiḥ kācid iti darśayaty ubhayor apīti darpaṇaparvatayoḥ.* "And [we] have already demonstrated that the essence of illusion is non-manifestation (*akhyāti*), that is to say, an incomplete manifestation (*apūrṇakhyāti*); but as regards the subject at hand, there is no non-manifestation whatsoever. This is what [Utpaladeva] shows [in his *Vivṛti*] with the words 'both of them [are manifest],' [which mean] 'both the mirror and the mountain [reflected in it are manifest].'"
67. See ĪPVV, vol. III, p. 242: *nanu darpaṇo'lpadeśo'lpaparimāṇaś ca, tadviparītas tu parvataḥ.* "But the mirror has a place and size that are small, whereas it is not the case of the mountain [reflected in the mirror]!" As for Utpaladeva's refutation of the objection, see ibid.: *etan nirākaroti deśaparimāṇavirodha eva nāstīti vadan vitatam apīty ādinā.* "With [the passage of the *Vivṛti* beginning with the words] 'even though it is large,' [Utpaladeva] refutes this [thesis] by explaining that [in fact] there is no contradiction whatsoever between the places and sizes [of the reflected object and its reflection]." This refutation was based on the fact that the place and size of the reflected object remain the same (the mountain does not become small simply because it is manifested in a mirror, nor does it recover its size when it is no longer reflected in the mirror). See ibid.: *tasya deśāder iti parvatadeśasya parvataparimāṇasya ca darpaṇadeśaparimāṇollaṅghanena prasaraṇaṃ yato nāsti.* "With [the passage beginning with the words] 'the place and so on,' [Utpaladeva explains that there is no such contradiction] because the place and size of the mountain [outside of the mirror] do not result from the fact that [the mountain] would abandon the place and size of the mirror [once it is no longer seen in the mirror]." And this shows that the reflection cannot be a mere illusion (ibid.): *nanv aprasaraṇaṃ cet, bhrāntatvam astu pītasyeva śuklollaṅghanenāprasarataḥ. atrocyate'tirodhanāc ceti pītena tu śuklaṃ tirodhīyata eva yato na khyātiḥ.* "[–Objection:] But if [the place and size of the mountain] do not result [from that, then] let [us] admit that [the reflection] is illusory, just as the yellow [seen on a conch by someone who has jaundice is illusory and] does not result from the fact that [the conch would really] abandon [its being] white! To this [objection Utpaladeva] replies with [the passage beginning with] 'and because there is no concealment'; [that is to say: there is no concealment of the mountain by its reflection,] whereas [in the case of the white mistaken for yellow,] because the yellow does conceal the white, there is no manifestation [of the white, and this non-manifestation is the characteristic of an erroneous cognition.]"
68. See, for example, PSV, p. 37: … *darpaṇas tattatpratibimbamayo'pi tebhyaḥ pratibimbebhyaḥ samuttīrṇasvarūpatayā cakāsti, na punas tanmayaḥ sampadyate yena ca na darpaṇa iti pratītiḥ syāt. sarvasya punas tattatpratibimbagrahaṇe'pi darpaṇo'yam ity abādhitā pratipattiḥ* … "… Although the mirror is made of various reflections, it is manifest as having a form that transcends these reflections, and it does not amount to nothing but these [reflections, in] which [case] as a consequence, [upon seeing reflections in a mirror we] would have the cognition '[this is] not a mirror': on the contrary, even when [we] grasp various reflections, [we] all have the cognition, uncontradicted [by some later cognition that would invalidate it], 'this is a mirror.'"

See Bansat-Boudon and Tripathi (2011, p. 114). Cf. MMP, p. 157: *nanūktam eva darpaṇe puruṣo nāstīti bādho'nubhūyata iti cet, na; darpaṇe yadi puruṣa āropyate, tadā sa tatra nāstīti bādho'pi syāt, naivam anubhavaḥ, tatra tacchāyāmātrasyaivopalambhaḥ, na tu tadvataḥ puṃsa ity anubhūyamānatvāt. ataś ca darpaṇe puruṣo'stīti yuktimatāṃ pratītyabhāvād etadbādho'pi nāsti.* "[The opponent] might [object the following:] But [we] have already stated that [the perception apprehending the reflection of e.g. a man in a mirror is an illusion because we] experience that [this cognition is] contradicted [by a later invalidating cognition taking the form] 'there is no man in the mirror'. [To this we reply]: no. If a man were [indeed wrongly] superimposed onto the mirror, then there could also be [later] an [invalidating] contradiction [in the form] 'this [man] is not in the mirror'. But experience is not so, because [we rather] experience that what [we] perceive is a mere reflection of the [man in the mirror,] but [in that mirror we do] not [perceive] the man [himself] to whom this [reflection] belongs. And so, since sensible [people] do not have a cognition [in the form] 'there is a man in the mirror' [when seeing the reflection of a man, they] do not [experience] either any [later] contradiction of this [thought]!"

69. See TĀ 3.12–13: *yas tv āha netratejāṃsi svacchāt pratiphalanty alam / viparyasya svakaṃ vaktraṃ gṛhṇantīti sa pṛcchyate // dehād anyatra yat tejas tadadhiṣṭhātur ātmanaḥ / tenaiva tejasā jñatve ko'rthaḥ syād darpaṇena tu //* "As for the proponent [of the thesis] that [when we stand in front of a mirror,] the visual rays are diverted by the limpid [surface of the mirror] enough to bounce back [and] grasp our own face, [we] ask him [the following question:] if one knows thanks to this very visual ray [which is capable of leaving] the body of the Self that governs it [so as to reside] in some other place, then what could be the use of the mirror?" Abhinavagupta does not specify why mirrors become useless if the theory of visual rays is adopted. One might assume that according to him, if we admit that visual organs can freely roam about outside of our body, there is no particular reason why they should not go backwards by themselves, so that the mirror becomes superfluous. According to Jayaratha, however, Abhinavagupta rather means that if the theory of visual rays is adopted, then any object capable of resistance should make the visual rays bounce back, and as a result we should see our faces reflected in walls as well as in mirrors. See TĀV, vol. II, pp. 14–15: … *puraḥpratiphalanahetūnām anyeṣām api kuḍyādīnāṃ tatra saṃbhavāt. atha darpaṇādaya eva pratiphalanahetavo na kuḍyādaya iti cet, svacchandābhidhānam etat, yataḥ samāne'pi pratighātahetutve darpaṇādaya eva tathā na kuḍyādaya ity atra na kiṃcin nimittam utpaśyāmaḥ.* "[Abhinavagupta says so] because in that case, other [things] too, such as a wall, could be the causes of [the visual rays'] bouncing back towards [our face]. If [our opponent replies]: 'But only such [things] as a mirror can be the causes of the [visual rays'] bouncing back[, and] not such [things as] a wall,' [we answer that] this is idle talk, since, given that [both the mirror and the wall] have in common the [property of] causing a resistance [which makes things bounce back], we do not see any reason why such [things] as a mirror would be thus and not such [things] as a wall!"

70. TĀ 3.14: *viparyastais tu tejobhir grāhakātmatvam āgataiḥ / rūpaṃ dṛśyeta vadane nije na makurāntare //* "Let [us admit] that [when we look at our own face in a mirror,] the [entity] grasping [the face] is the [visual] rays once they have bounced back; [but if this were the case, we] should see the visual form in our own face [and] not in something else[, i.e.] the mirror." This criticism seems to echo Śāntarakṣita's (cf. above, n. 39).

71. See ĪPVV, vol. III, p. 242 (quoting VP 1.100): *yad āha: viruddhaparimāṇeṣu vajrādarśatalādiṣu / parvatādisarūpāṇāṃ bhāvānāṃ nāsti sambhavaḥ //* "As [Bhartṛhari] has stated: '[Objective] entities having the form of e.g. a mountain cannot exist on the surface of such [reflecting entities as] a diamond or a mirror, [since this surface] has a size that is contradictory [with objective entities such as the mountain]."'
72. In the passage mentioned here Bhartṛhari merely shows that just as reflected entities seem to take some of the properties of the reflecting entity but do not really possess them (the mountain does not really become as small as the diamond reflecting it), speech seems to be temporally differentiated whereas in fact it is not. See, for example, VPV, p. 101: *upalabdhiviṣayatāpattau tu teṣām abhinnakālānām upalabdhisthityabhimānaḥ.* "But when these [linguistic realities] that do not have a differentiated temporality become the objects of a perception, the belief [arises in ordinary people] that these [syllables, words, sentences, etc.] have the [temporally differentiated] existence of the perception [that grasps them]."
73. See, for example, ĪPVV, vol. III, pp. 243–244, where the interlocutor is explicitly designated as a Vijñānavādin, and where Utpaladeva's goal is still to show "the difference [between the manifestation of reflections] and an illusion" (*bhrānter vailakṣaṇyam*, ibid., p. 244).
74. See his introduction to TĀ 3.12 in TĀV, vol. II, p. 13: … *keṣāṃcana naiyāyikānāṃ pratyāvṛttair nayanaraśmibhiḥ svasyaiva mukhasya grahaṇe'pi darpaṇe mukham* iti bhrāntir iyam na punaḥ satyatvabhrāntatvavyatirekeṇa tṛtīyasya rāśyantarasyābhāvāt pratibimbaṃ nāma kiṃcid astīti mataṃ nirākartum āha …* [**darpaṇe mukham* conjecture: *darpaṇamukham* TĀV.] "[Abhinavagupta now] states [the following verses] in order to refute the opinion of some Naiyāyikas according to whom even though [when seeing one's face in a mirror,] one grasps one's own face thanks to the visual rays that have bounced back, the [cognition] of the face [as being] in the mirror is an illusion, and since there is no third option besides reality and illusion, what [we] call a reflection is nothing at all."
75. See TĀV, vol. II, pp. 13–14 on TĀ 3.12: *ya ity ekavacanena sūtrakārāsūtritatvāt sarveṣāṃ naiyāyikānāṃ naitan matam iti sūcitam, kaiścid eva hy āgrahapravṛttair etad uktam iti bhāvaḥ. ata eva vṛttikārabhūṣaṇakārādibhir etan nāmāpi na spṛṣṭam.* "With the [use of the] singular in 'the one who says …', [Abhinavagupta] hints at the fact that this is not the opinion of all Naiyāyikas, since it has not been declared in any aphorism by the author of the [*Nyāya*]*sūtra*s; for this has only been stated by some whimsical ones—this is the implicit idea. For this very reason, this [thesis] has not been mentioned at all by the author of the *Vṛtti*, [i.e., Jayanta Bhaṭṭa], or by the author of the [*Nyāya*]*bhūṣaṇa*, [i.e., Bhāsarvajña,] etc." On Jayanta Bhaṭṭa's identity with the "author of the *Vṛtti*," see, for example, Steinkellner (1961, p. 159) and Gupta (1963, p. 15).
76. Pakṣilasvāmin is mentioned as "the author of the *Nyāyabhāṣya*" (*nyāyabhāṣyakṛt*) in ĪPV, vol. II, p. 84, and Uddyotakara's name appears in ĪPVV, vol. I, p. 40.
77. On this thesis (certainly already formulated in Utpaladeva's *Vivṛti* on ĪPK 1.2.8), see Ratié (2011a, pp. 276–289).
78. See, for example, TĀ 3.9: *nairmalyaṃ mukhyam ekasya saṃvinnāthasya sarvataḥ / aṃśāṃśikātaḥ kvāpy anyad vimalaṃ tat tadicchayā //* "Limpidity belongs fundamentally [and] entirely to the unitary Lord that is consciousness; any other limpid [entity] is so only in some respects, in part, and by virtue of this [Lord's]

will." The reason for this is that limpidity is defined in the Śaiva nondualistic system as a capacity to be manifest without being limited to any specific form, and only consciousness is endowed with a capacity to manifest itself in countless forms (as we all experience, for example, in imagination: see Ratié [2010b]). See in particular TĀ 3.48: *atyantasvacchatā sā yat svākṛtyanavabhāsanam / ataḥ svacchatamo bodho na ratnaṃ tv ākṛtigrahāt* // "Absolute limpidity is [the ability] not to be manifest [only] in one's own individual form; as a consequence, only consciousness is absolutely limpid, whereas a crystal is not, because it is possessed of an individual form."

79. On the Naiyāyikas' limpidity (*prasāda*) defined as the material property (i.e. according to most interpretations, a particular color) distinguishing reflecting entities from other objects, see, for example, Preisendanz (1989, pp. 193–199; 1994, pp. 587–589).
80. See, for example, TĀV, vol. II, p. 15 (immediately after arguing that the theory of diverted visual rays does not explain the difference between mirrors and, for example, walls: see above, n. 69): *athātrādhikaḥ svacchatvākhyo dharmo'sti nimittam iti cet, naitat, svacchatvaṃ hi na pratighāte nimittam, evaṃ hy ālokasya svacchatvāt tasmin sati nabhasi na kasyāpy avakāśaḥ syāt pratyuta tat pratibimbagrahaṇe nimittam.* "If [the opponent replies] that there is a cause for the [fact that only things such as mirrors can reflect something else, i.e.] an additional property [that only belongs to these things and is] called limpidity, this is not [right]; for limpidity is not the cause of resistance[, contrary to what your theory of diverted rays presupposes]. For if it were the case, [then] since there is [light] in the sky, given that light is limpid there should be no room for anything [but light in the sky]! Rather, this [limpidity must be defined as] the cause of [our] apprehending a reflection."
81. See Ratié (2014c, pp. 210–218).
82. See, for example, Potter (1981, pp. 16 and 118); Granoff (1985, p. 465) mentions a similar story (although in the latter Śaṅkara triumphs on his own and survives).
83. As regards the dualistic Śaivasiddhānta, a telling example is found in Sanderson (2006, pp. 68ff.) which establishes a probable date for Sadyojyotis notably from the fact that he was not aware of the doctrine of "illusionism" (*vivartavāda*) propounded by Śaṅkara and Maṇḍanamiśra, contrary to later Saiddhāntikas who criticize both the latter and the earlier Vedāntic "transformationism" (*pariṇāmavāda*). As for Śaiva nondualism, see ŚD 6.3 ff. where Somānanda attacks several types of Vedānta.
84. Only one verse in Utpaladeva's work explicitly criticizes the Vedānta's monism, namely, ĪPK 2.4.20.
85. While presenting the Śaiva *pratibimbavāda*, Maheśvarānanda engages in a lengthy criticism of the main Vedāntin theories regarding the ontological status of the phenomenal world in a passage (MMP, p. 155) beginning thus: *nanv asti vivartaḥ pariṇāmādir veti cet, na …* "If [an opponent objects the following to this doctrine that phenomena are similar to reflections:] 'But there is an illusory transformation (*vivarta*) [of the Brahman], or a real transformation (*pariṇāma*), etc.', [we reply:] No …" See also the conclusion of this discussion in MMP, p. 159: *iti vivartādivyati-rekeṇāsmadupakṣiptaḥ-pratibimbapakṣa eva prauḍhim āḍhaukate.* "Thus this thesis propounded by us that [phenomena are similar to] reflections attains perfection when distinguished from [the Vedāntins' theory of] illusory transformation, etc."
86. On the vedānticization of Abhinavagupta's ontology by his commentator Bhāskarakaṇṭha (seventeenth century?), see Ratié (2013).
87. See ŚD 6.11: *pratibimbatayā cānye ye vā sargamukhe svayam / brahmaiva gṛhṇāty ātmānaṃ ato bhedopapādanam* // "And other [Vedāntins say that] it is the Brahman itself that grasps itself by itself in the form of a reflection at the beginning of the

[cosmic] emission; [and] this is how difference is possible [despite the fact that only the unitary Brahman exists]."

88. Unfortunately this part of the ŚDV has not come down to us.
89. On the critique of Vedānta monism in ĪPK 2.4.20 and its commentaries, see Ratié (2011a, pp. 668–713).
90. Modern scholarship has often assumed that Abhinavagupta knew Śaṅkara's works (or even had the "same" conception of ultimate reality: see Pandey [1936, p. 151]). According to Sanderson (1985, p. 210, en. 41), however, in the Kashmiri Śaiva works of the tenth and eleventh centuries "it is the doctrine of Maṇḍanamiśra which is generally in mind," while "no source betrays familiarity with the doctrines of Śaṅkara." As noted in Bansat-Boudon and Tripathi (2011, p. 8, fn. 41), determining whether they were acquainted with Maṇḍana's tradition rather than Śaṅkara's is no easy task though. What is certain is that we should be wary of assuming that Śaṅkara's works *had* to be known by any posterior author somehow acquainted with Advaita Vedānta, because Śaṅkara's fame might well be a rather late phenomenon. Besides, as shown in Ratié (2011a, pp. 669–680; 2010b, pp. 364–369), Abhinavagupta's commentaries sometimes seem to paraphrase Maṇḍanamiśra's BSi; and since Abhinavagupta at least (and maybe Utpaladeva as well) probably knew some of Vācaspatimiśra's works (see Ratié 2014a, p. 134, fn. 30), it is quite possible that one of their main sources regarding Vedāntic ontology was the beginning (alas lacking to date) of Vācaspatimiśra's *Tattvasamīkṣā.*
91. See also nn. 104 and 106 below.
92. See, for example, ĪPVV, vol. III, p. 238: *svacchatvasyāyaṃ prabhāva ukto bhavati, na tu pratibimbatāyāḥ pratibimbādirūpasya svayam asāratvāt.* "[Utpaladeva] explains that this is the power of limpidity, as opposed to [the property of] being a reflection, because what consists in such a [thing] as a reflection has no essence by itself." Cf., for example, *Tantrasāra*, p. 10: *… sarvam idaṃ bhāvajātaṃ bodhagagane pratibimbamātraṃ pratibimbalakṣaṇopetatvād idaṃ hi pratibimbasya lakṣaṇaṃ yad bhedena bhāsitum* aśaktam anyavyāmiśratvenaiva bhāti tat pratibimbam …* [**bhāsitum* conjecture: *bhāsitam Tantrasāra.*] "All these [objective] entities [constituting the perceived universe] are nothing but reflections on the firmament of consciousness, because they have the status that characterizes reflections. For this is the characteristic of any reflection: that which, while it cannot be manifested independently, is only manifest as being mixed with [a reflecting entity that appears to be] distinct [from it], is a reflection." Cf., for example, TĀV, vol. II, p. 65 (explaining TĀ 3.56 quoted below, n. 97): *tato'nyasmāt tadākāragrahaṇasahiṣṇor darpaṇāder bhedena pṛthak svātantryeṇāśakyaṃ bhāsanaṃ yasya tat, tat paratantram ity arthaḥ.* "Therefore [a reflection is] that whose manifestation cannot occur 'independently', [i.e.] separately [or] autonomously with respect to another [entity] such as a mirror, which is capable of taking on its aspect; i.e. this [reflection] is heteronomous (*paratantra*)."
93. See the testimony of Utpaladeva himself in ŚDV, p. 14: *viśvātmatvaṃ ca cinmayasya pratibimbānām iva darpaṇaparamārthatvena bhāvānāṃ svacchacinmātrasatattvatayāvasthānāt. etac ca sarvam īśvarapratyabhijñāṭīkāyāṃ nipuṇam ālocitam.* "And that which consists in consciousness takes the form of the universe, because entities exist while having as their reality nothing but a limpid consciousness, just as reflections [only exist] while having the mirror as their ultimate reality; and [I] have exhaustively shown all this in [my] detailed commentary on [my] *Īśvarapratyabhijñā* [treatise]." For somewhat different interpretations of this passage, see Nemec (2011, pp. 117–118) and Ratié (2014a, p. 163, fn. 116).

94. ĪPVV, vol. II, p. 81 : *darpaṇasya lagnatvena yathā pratibimbāni bhānti, na tu darpaṇābhedam anādṛtya svātmaparinisṭhitāni, tathāmī ghaṭādayas tasyaiva prakāśasya lagnās tadanujīvitā nirbhāsante; na svaniṣṭhitā iti.*
95. See, for example, TĀ 3.23c: *na cāvastutvaṃ syān na ca kim api sāraṃ nijam iti.* "And [this reflection] cannot be unreal; yet neither can [it] have any essence of its own."
96. Abhinavagupta often explains that phenomena seem to be "over and above" consciousness or "distinct from" it *(adhika,* lit. "[something] more") although in fact they are not so, just as reflections seem to be distinct from the mirror while their manifestation depends on their unity with the mirror. See, for example, ĪPVV, vol. III, p. 343: *etad eva hi tan nirmalatvaṃ yat svātmānatiriktasyāpy atiriktasyevāvabhāsanam.* "For this is precisely what limpidity is: the manifestation of [the reflecting entity] as if it were distinct, although [in fact] it is not distinct from itself." Cf., for example, ĪPVV, vol. II, p. 404: … *pratibimbakalpatayānatiriktair apy atiriktābhāsair arthair nīlasukhādibhiḥ* … "… Objects, such as blue or pleasure, which, in the manner of reflections, appear as distinct [from consciousness] although [in fact] they are not …" Abhinavagupta's disciple, Kṣemarāja, is particularly fond of this idea (see, e.g., Ratié [2011a, fn. 54, p. 668 and p. 693]).
97. See, for example, ĪPVV, vol. III, p. 239: *yad vinā yan nīrūpam apṛthagbhūtam api pṛthagbhūtatayeva nirbhāsate, tat tatra pratibimbam iti pratibimbasāmānyalakṣaṇaṃ cidapekṣayāsti bhāvānām*. "An [entity A] which is unsubstantial *(nīrūpa)* without an [entity B, and] is manifest as if it were distinct [from the entity B] whereas [in fact] it is not distinct [from it], is a reflection inside that [entity B]; therefore [the analogy is legitimate because] with respect to consciousness, [objective] entities have this characteristic in common with reflections." See also TĀ 3.56–57: *anyavyāmiśraṇāyogāt tadbhedāśakyabhāsanam / pratibimbam iti prāhur darpaṇe vadanaṃ yathā // bodhamiśram idaṃ bodhād bhedenāśakyabhāsanam / paratattvādi bodhe kiṃ pratibimbaṃ na bhaṇyate //* "What [we] call a 'reflection' is a manifestation that, because it is mixed with [an entity that appears to be] distinct [from it], cannot exist independently of this [other entity]—just as a face in a mirror. The manifestation which, from the supreme ontological principle (*tattva*) [from which cosmic emanation proceeds to the last of them] is within consciousness, mixed with consciousness, [and] cannot exist independently [of consciousness], why shouldn't [we] call it a reflection?"
98. See, for example, Abhinavagupta's treatment of this objection in TĀ 3.52–53: *nanu bimbasya virahe pratibimbaṃ kathaṃ bhavet / kiṃ kurmo dṛśyate tad dhi nanu tad bimbam ucyatām // naivaṃ tallakṣaṇābhāvād bimbaṃ kila kim ucyate / anyāmiśraṃ svatantraṃ sad bhāsamānaṃ mukhaṃ yathā //* " [– An objector:] But how could there be a reflection if there is no reflected object? [– Abhinavagupta:] What shall we do [then]? For we do perceive this [reflection that is the phenomenal world]!—But [then] let [us] call this [phenomenal world] a reflected object—It [can]not [be] so; for how can it be said that [the phenomenal world] is a reflected object? For it does not have the characteristics of this [reflected object, namely the properties of] existing [and] being manifest while not being mixed with anything else [and] while being autonomous, contrary to e.g. a face [that is manifest even in the absence of a mirror]."
99. On this demonstration, see Ratié (2011b).
100. *darpaṇavidhiḥ* (TĀ 3.23d).

101. This point was explained by Utpaladeva in his lost *Vivṛti* on ĪPK 2.4.19 while he expounded the mirror analogy. See ĪPVV, vol. III, p. 244: *nanu cidrūpābhedena prakāśanam asiddham ahambhāvabahiṣkāreṇa nīlādināṃ pratyayād ity āśaṅkyāha māyāpramātur iti …* "Having anticipated the [following objection, Utpaladeva] states [the passage beginning with] 'for the subject [deluded] by *māyā* …' [in his *Vivṛti*]: 'But [although reflections are seen not to be distinct from the mirror manifesting them,] it is not established that [the phenomenal world] is manifest while not being distinct from what consists in consciousness; for [objects] such as blue are perceived as being external to [the perceiver's] subjectivity [expressed as 'I', while objects are apprehended as 'this']."
102. On this point made by Utpaladeva in a somewhat different context, see Ratié (2014a, pp. 161–163). Cf., for example, PSV, p. 40: *itthaṃ parameśvarāpekṣayā svāṅganirmite bhāvarāśau na kācid bhedabhrāntir māyāpramātrapekṣayā tu yo'yaṃ bhedāvabhāsaḥ. eṣāpūrṇatvākhyātirūpā bhrāntiḥ, pūrṇasyādvayātmano rūpasyākhyānam aprathā, pūrṇaṃ na bhāsate, kiṃtv apūrṇaṃ dvayarūpaṃ bhāsate; bheda eva pratīyata iti yāvat. tasmān niravadyo'yaṃ pratibimbavādaḥ.* "Thus from the Highest Lord's point of view there is no illusion whatsoever of a difference [between consciousness and] all the [objective] entities that are created out of parts of [consciousness] itself; but from the point of view of the subject deluded by *māyā,* there is such a manifestation [of the universe] as different [from the consciousness reflecting it]. This [differentiated manifestation] is an illusion consisting in an incomplete manifestation. [That is, this illusion is only] the non-manifestation of the full, [i.e.] nondual nature [of consciousness manifesting the universe. This nature] is not fully manifest, rather it is manifest as having an incomplete, [i.e.] a dual form; that is to say, only difference is apprehended [and not the unity on which it rests]. Therefore this thesis that [phenomena are similar to] reflections *(pratibimbavāda)* is blameless." See Bansat-Boudon and Tripathi (2011, pp. 116–117).
103. See, for example, TĀ 3.44, which points out that the freedom of consciousness is manifest in the very midst of the phenomenal universe reflected in it: *tena saṃvittimakure viśvam ātmānam arpayat / nāthasya vadate'muṣya vimalāṃ viśvarūpatām //* "Therefore the universe, while projecting itself [as a reflection] on the mirror of consciousness, expresses this Lord's limpid existence in the form of the universe."
104. On this idea in Maṇḍanamiśra's BSi, see above, n. 57. Cf. TĀV, vol. II, p. 55, which also points to a Vedāntin context (compare with, e.g., the BSBh passage quoted above, n. 56): *iha khalu rūpādayaḥ pratibimbitāḥ santaḥ svādhāropādhivaiśiṣṭyenaivāvabhāsante, yathā khaḍge taddharmordhvatādyuparaktatayā mukham …* "In this [world], for sure, a visual form and so on, while being reflected, are manifest only as being particularized by the adventitious properties of their [reflecting] support, just as a face [reflected] in a sword [that is manifest] while having its appearance affected by properties of this [sword] such as its [particular] length . . ."
105. According to TĀ 3.24–43, the objects of the five senses can be reflected (thus echoes, for instance, are presented as reflections of sounds).
106. TĀ 3.45–46: *yathā ca gandharūpaspṛgrasādyāḥ pratibimbitāḥ / tadādhāroparāgeṇa bhānti khaḍge mukhādivat // tathā viśvam idaṃ bodhe pratibimbitam āśrayet / prakāśatvasvatantratvaprabhṛtiṃ dharmavistaram //*

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